

time. He shook himself out of his stupor, turned to Akeya and looked him in the eye, his own eyes filled with sadness, compassion and pity, and finding the same in return. A tear trickled down the old man's cheek. Akeya gently wiped the tear away with his thumb and together, arm in arm, one supporting the other, they made their way back home in grim silence.

This was going to be a hard year. A very hard year.

Somewhere in India

Hari woke up at 0600 every day like clockwork. He didn't need an alarm, the early morning rush of activity, the hastening footsteps of incoming travellers at the station, the hawkers setting up their stalls at the station, all these served as an unerring wake-up alarm. He yawned and stretched, wrapping his ragged rug a little tighter around himself, for the morning still had a bit of chill in the air, and he didn't feel like much activity just yet. Still, he mustn't dally too much, he wouldn't want someone else to take his spot.

Sighing, he extricated himself from the rug and carefully wrapped his few belongings into the same rug, stashing the package away in the little cranny that he had made exclusively for that purpose. He grabbed his little plastic mug and made his way to the water pump by the side of the track, leisurely performing his morning



Any old PC can enlighten the lives of the young and willing

ablutions and wondering what he'd have for breakfast. The last few days hadn't really offered much variety, only offering him a couple of vada pavs here, or a missal pav there, maybe he'd get lucky today and someone would offer him a croissant! He'd developed a liking for those, it was too bad that the stall was running out of business, these commuters really had no taste!

Ablutions completed, he donned his garb, threw some loose change into his

cup and set about his morning routine. Loitering about the food stalls, he set about shamelessly trying to guilt people into parting with their food, particularly focusing on the ones with the croissants! Today was his lucky day. Within the hour, Hari had amassed for himself quite a wholesome breakfast, consisting of a couple of vada pavs, a chocolate croissant, a half-eaten bun and a steaming Caffe Mocha that a kindly gentleman had passed on to him before leaping into a train.

Satisfied for the time-being, Hari unhurriedly set off for the end of the platform, settling on the edge and nibbling his bounty. Chunmun, noticing said bounty decided to pop over, hoping for some tasty snack as well. Chunmun was an old pal, Hari's constant companion these past two years, the only creature with which he felt some sort of kinship. They made an odd pair, an arthritic rhesus macaque and a ragged old man sitting side by side, sharing vada pavs; but most of the regulars were used to the sight by now and treated it with the vast indifference that comes from the rut of a routine.

They were both old and tired creatures in their own right, with nothing much to look forward to but a comfortable existence till the end of their days. On his more hungry nights (which were thankfully few), Hari would recall the privations in his village, the wife and daughter that he had lost to a severe drought and famine,

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The Bill and Melinda Gates foundation is the largest, privately held foundation in the world and is the among the largest, if not the largest (barring maybe the UN), forces for good in the world today.

Established in 1997 with a "mere" two billion dollars in funding, the foundation now functions with an endowment in excess of 42 billion USD (28 billion of which came from Bill Gates's own pocket). The program has been at the forefront in ushering a sea-change in the world with regards to problems like food, healthcare and governance. It's done more for the well being of the planet and the underprivileged than almost every other charitable foundation combined.

Going from something as simple as bringing Internet to public libraries, it has tackled problems like HIV/AIDS in India, spent millions of dollars on anti-malaria research, launched a green revolution in Africa and now seeks to completely eradicate at least four different diseases (including Malaria and Polio) in the next decade or so.

Speaking of diseases, the foundation announced in 2010 that this will be the decade of the vaccine and have spent millions of dollars on research, the distribution of vaccines and the sanitation of infected areas. With help from others, the foundation has helped cut down infant mortality by more than half and hope to further double survivability over the next few years.

For more information, be sure to check out <http://dgit.in/1DNZLhc> for a detailed overview of what the foundation does and what it hopes to achieve.